3.1 Agricultural Production

The basics of farming haven't changed. Farmers today need fertile soil and a good climate to grow abundant crops, just like their counterparts in the colonies. Good climates in the Middle Colonies attracted immigrant farmers from Britain and other parts of Europe.

MAIN IDEA The fertile land of the Middle Colonies allowed farmers to raise cash crops and livestock for sale and export, resulting in a booming economy.

FARMLAND AND FREEDOM

Just like the settlers of New England and the Southern Colonies, immigrants who came to the Middle Colonies of New York, New Jersey, Pennsylvania, and Delaware found ways to support themselves in their new environment. There were navigable rivers and harbors, and rich farmland rolled across the region. The area's weather was warmer than New England's but avoided the sticky heat farther south. Settlers soon discovered that grains such as wheat, corn, rye, and barley thrived in the climate. As a result, the region earned the nickname "breadbasket of the colonies."

Immigrants from all over Europe heard about the **arable**, or fertile, land and decided to move to the Middle Colonies. Attracted by cheap land, limited government control, and religious tolerance, more than 100,000 Germans immigrated to the area between 1683 and 1783.

The majority of Germans headed for the backcountry of Pennsylvania. They brought with them new farming techniques, such as providing shelter for their animals in the winter. Some farmers used indentured servants and enslaved people to tend their fields. As the settlers grew wealthier, they sold more of their harvest as cash crops and raised livestock for sale and export.

The residents of the breadbasket enjoyed more prosperous lives than farmers in New England. Unfortunately, there was a cost—though not directly to the settlers. Their growing farms continued to edge out the Native Americans who lived on the land.

GRIST FOR THE MILL

Many Middle Colony farmers grew grains, and wheat was the most popular grain in colonial America. The plant made a finer flour than corn, which in turn produced softer bread. Colonists enjoyed wheat bread with their meals, but making the flour required grinding. Grinding the grain by hand took a long time and resulted in flour that was rough in texture. Farmers found they could save time and energy by taking their wheat to a **gristmill**, a building that housed machinery for grinding grain.

Since human and animal labor was in short supply in the Middle Colonies, many colonists built their gristmills near a river and harnessed the power of water to operate the gristmill. At that time, water mills were the latest technology. The water spun a wheel outside that turned grinding stones within the gristmill.

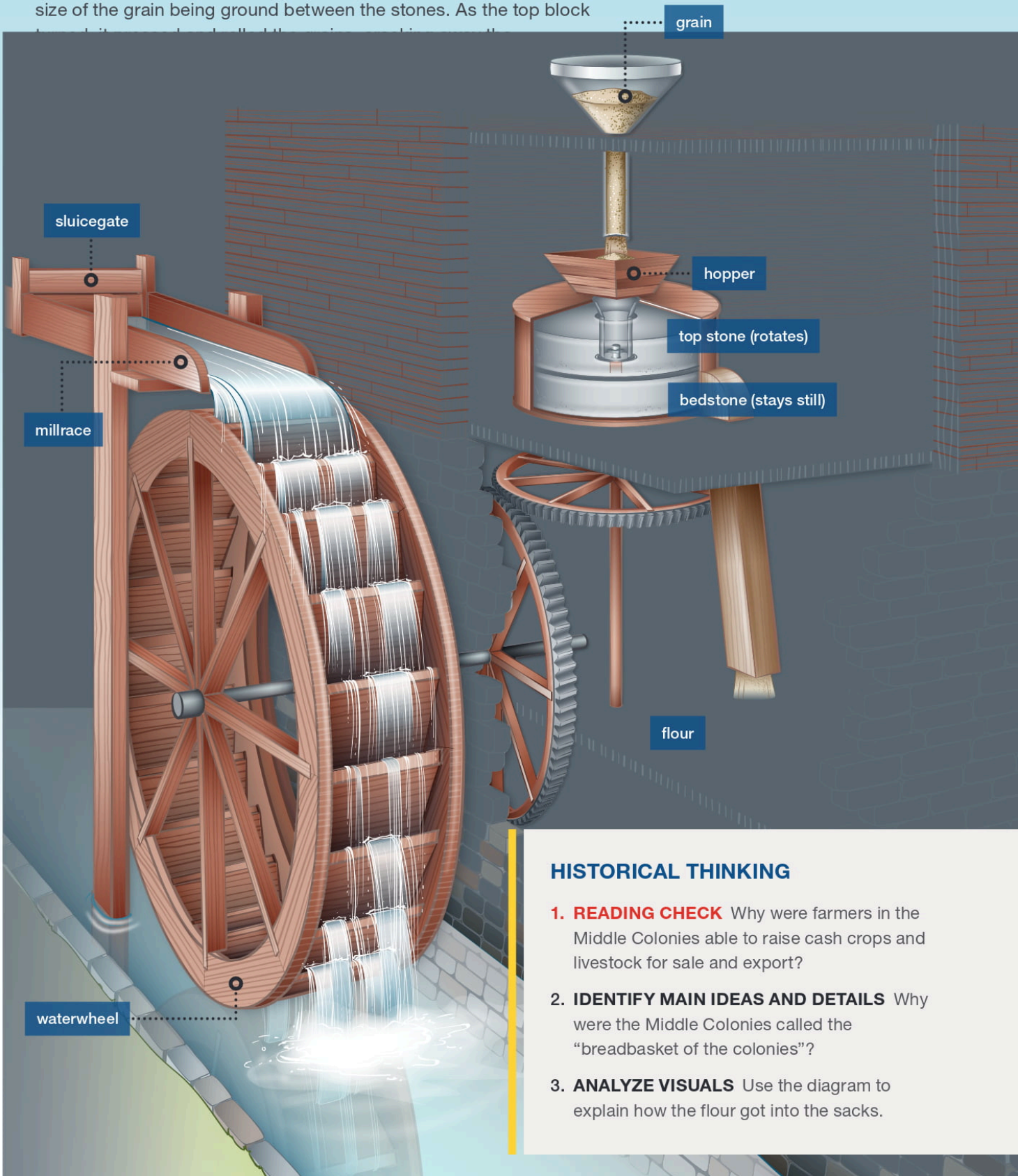
Workers called millers ran the gristmills and generally took a portion of the flour they ground as payment. They also took other goods in exchange. Some millers opened stores to sell the surplus flour, grain, or other goods. These stores became the centers of communities. Neighbors would gather there to exchange goods and catch up on news. As demand grew, some millers bought larger mills or moved their mill to a spot on the river with a faster current.

But not all of the immigrants who came to the Middle Colonies became farmers or millers. Some settled in the cities hoping to find greater opportunities in the fast-growing coastal towns.

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How a Gristmill Works

With the exception of a few metal parts and the stone grinding blocks, most colonial gristmills were made of wood. Some had foundations of stone. A channel called a millrace was dug from a stream or river to direct fast-running water to the waterwheel. Water falling from the millrace turned the wheel. The moving waterwheel then turned gears inside the building, which rotated the top grinding block. This block could be raised and lowered to vary its closeness to the bottom block, depending upon the size of the grain being ground between the stones. As the top block



HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why were farmers in the Middle Colonies able to raise cash crops and livestock for sale and export?
2. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** Why were the Middle Colonies called the "breadbasket of the colonies"?
3. **ANALYZE VISUALS** Use the diagram to explain how the flour got into the sacks.

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